Practice Raising a Care Concern Long Before You Have One

Four prompts to describe a concern using a made-up example, agree how your family will raise worries with each other, write a short script you could use with any provider, and prepare the contact questions for when care begins.

Where you are

Your husband is doing fine, and you've never had to challenge a nurse, an aide, or a doctor about anything. You know that if care ever becomes part of your lives, you'd rather know how to say something than find out in the middle of being upset.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You've practiced one factual concern message, your family has agreed how to tell each other when something seems off, and you have a blank contact plan ready to fill in the day care starts.

A one-page advocacy practice sheet: How we describe a concern, How we raise it with each other, A practice script, and Contacts to confirm when care begins.

Before you start

- A memory of a time, anywhere in life, when you wished you'd spoken up and didn't.
- The names of relatives who would want to be told if something seemed wrong.
- Your own honest sense of how comfortable you are with conflict. None of this needs to be written down yet.

PROMPT 1

See the difference between a complaint and a concern

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most of us have only ever complained. A concern is a different thing: dates, what was seen, who saw it, and the part of the plan it touches. Seeing the two side by side teaches more than any list of rules.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

No paperwork at all; the example is invented, so ten quiet minutes is plenty.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My husband doesn't need care yet, and I want to practice describing a care concern before I ever have one. Invent a small, ordinary concern a family might notice in [HOME CARE OR A CARE

> RESIDENCE], nothing dramatic, and write it two ways: first as a frustrated family member might blurt it out, then as a factual message with dates, what was observed, who observed it, and which part of a care plan it relates to. Then list the differences between the two versions as rules I can remember. Label the example clearly as fictional, and don't include anything about medication or injury.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The gap between the two versions. Your rules list is the lesson.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Write your own fictional example in the factual style and keep it with the rules.

PROMPT 2

Agree how your family will raise a worry with each other

WHY THIS MATTERS

Before anyone speaks to a provider, the family has to agree what it's asking for. Families that skip this send three relatives with three different messages, and staff stop listening to all of them.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The names of the relatives who'd want to know, and a line about how each handles worry and disagreement.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the people who'd want to know if something seemed wrong with my husband's care someday, and what I know about how each of them handles worry and disagreement:
>
> [PASTE NAMES AND A LINE ABOUT EACH]
>
> Draft a short family agreement, no more than ten lines, covering: how we tell each other about a concern and how quickly, who writes it down, how we decide together what we're asking for before anyone speaks to a provider, and what we do when we disagree with each other. Phrase it as questions for us to answer together rather than as rules you've chosen for us.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The question your family will argue about. That's the one to settle now, while it's hypothetical.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the questions to everyone named and set a time to answer them together.

PROMPT 3

Write a short script you could use with any provider

WHY THIS MATTERS

Polite and clear are not opposites. A script you've said aloud once at the kitchen table is the thing that lets you be both when it matters.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The factual version and the rules from Prompt 1.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Using this fictional concern and my family's rules for describing one:
>
> [PASTE THE FACTUAL VERSION AND THE RULES FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Write a script of about 120 words that I could adapt for a nurse, aide, or care manager: a respectful opening, the dated facts, the plan item it connects to, one specific request, and a closing question about when and from whom I'll hear back. Then write three one-line responses I could use if the person becomes defensive, changes the subject, or says they'll look into it without saying when. Keep everything neutral, with no accusations and no opinion of the care.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Lines you could say in your own voice. Change any word you wouldn't actually use.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read it aloud once to your husband or a friend. Notice that it is both polite and clear.

PROMPT 4

Prepare the contact plan you'll fill in later

WHY THIS MATTERS

You can't know the names yet. You can know the blanks. A page that already asks who the routine contact is, who covers nights, and how concerns are heard means you'll ask on the first day instead of the first bad day.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The rules, the family questions, and the script from the earlier prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is my practice work on speaking up about my husband's future care:
>
> [PASTE PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Lay it out on one page under four headings: HOW WE DESCRIBE A CONCERN, HOW WE RAISE IT WITH EACH OTHER, A PRACTICE SCRIPT, and CONTACTS TO CONFIRM WHEN CARE BEGINS. Under the last heading, create blank fields for: routine contact for family questions, who to call outside office hours, how the provider prefers to hear concerns, who handles a concern that isn't resolved, and the local emergency number. Mark every field TO CONFIRM WITH PROVIDER and leave them empty. Do not guess any contact or process.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that's half blanks, labeled honestly. Filling it in is one of the first things to do when care starts.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Store it with your husband's planning papers and add the date you made it.

Start with who he is, not with what might go wrong

The best preparation for speaking up is a clear, shared description of the person you're speaking up for. The care interview organizes your husband's situation into a Family Care Profile, the file your practice scripts and future contacts can sit beside.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›